STRENGTH & MOBILITY

A simple routine you can do at home with no equipment, plus stretching and balance, to stay strong and keep moving well.

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Strength keeps you able to carry water, climb stairs, get up off the floor and lift a child, and it protects your joints and bones. Adults should work **all major muscle groups on 2 or more days a week** (legs, hips, back, chest, shoulders, arms and core). Older adults should add balance training.

1. HOW TO DO IT

- **Reps and sets:** do each exercise 8 to 12 times (one set), until another one would be hard to do with good form. Start with 1 set; work up to 2 or 3.
- **Rest days:** give each muscle group a day off in between, such as Monday and Thursday.
- **Breathe:** breathe out as you push or lift; don't hold your breath.
- **Form first:** slow and controlled. If you can't keep good form, choose the easier version.
- **Progress:** when 12 reps feel easy for 2 sessions in a row, choose the harder version or add a set.
- **Pain:** working muscles may feel tired or a little sore the next day. Sharp or joint pain means stop.

2. THE HOME ROUTINE

EXERCISE	HOW	EASIER	HARDER
Chair squat	Stand in front of a sturdy chair, feet shoulder-width. Sit back until you lightly touch the seat, then stand up, pushing through your heels.	Use your hands on the armrests.	Don't touch the chair; hold a jug of water.
Push-up	Hands on a wall, counter or floor, slightly wider than shoulders. Keep your body straight; lower your chest, then push away.	Wall push-up.	Counter, then knees, then full push-up on the floor.
Glute bridge	Lie on your back, knees bent, feet flat. Squeeze your buttocks and lift your hips until knees, hips and shoulders line up. Lower slowly.	Smaller lift.	One foot at a time.
Row	Loop a resistance band around a post, or bend over with a hand on a table and a water jug in the other hand. Pull your elbow back, squeezing your shoulder blade.	Lighter band or jug.	Heavier jug; slower lowering.
Step-up	Step up onto the bottom stair with one foot, bring the other up, step down. Hold the rail. Switch the leading leg.	Lower step.	Higher step; carry weight.
Overhead press	Standing, hold water bottles or cans at shoulder height and press them overhead, then lower.	Seated; lighter items.	Heavier jugs.
Plank	Forearms and toes on the floor, body in a straight line. Hold 10 to 30 seconds.	On your knees, or against a counter.	Hold longer, up to 60 seconds.
Calf raise	Hold a counter. Rise up onto your toes, then lower slowly.	Both feet.	One foot at a time.

3. STRETCHING

Stretch **2 to 3 days a week or more**, best when your muscles are warm (after a walk). Hold each stretch **10 to 30 seconds** (30 to 60 seconds for older adults), 2 to 4 times. Feel a gentle pull, never pain, and don't bounce.

- **Calf:** hands on a wall, one leg back, heel down.
- **Hamstring:** sit on the edge of a chair, one leg straight with heel on the floor; lean forward from the hips.
- **Hip flexor:** half-kneel on a cushion; shift your hips gently forward.
- **Chest:** forearm on a door frame; turn your body away.
- **Shoulder:** bring one arm across your chest; hold it with the other.
- **Neck:** ear toward shoulder, slowly, each side.

4. BALANCE (ESPECIALLY OVER 65)

- Stand on one foot, holding a counter, for up to 30 seconds. Switch. As it gets easier, use one finger, then no hands.
- Heel-to-toe walk along a hallway wall, as if on a tightrope.
- Tai chi classes improve balance and reduce falls.
- Falls are a leading cause of injury in older adults; ask your provider about a fall-risk check.

5. LOG

DATE	SQUAT	PUSH-UP	BRIDGE	ROW	STEP-UP	PLANK	STRETCH / BALANCE

Write reps x sets (for example 10x2), or seconds for the plank.

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. U.S. Department of Health and Human Services: Physical Activity Guidelines for Americans, 2nd edition. health.gov/our-work/nutrition-physical-activity/physical-activity-guidelines
2. American College of Sports Medicine: resistance training and flexibility guidance. acsm.org
3. National Institute on Aging: Exercise and Physical Activity; Falls Prevention. nia.nih.gov
4. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: STEADI older adult fall prevention. cdc.gov/falls

IMPORTANT: Check with your health-care provider before starting if you have a heart condition, joint or back problems, osteoporosis, recent surgery, or are pregnant.